religious violence], what are our local partners doing about this?' I try to say 'well you know many of our partners are part of the problem'" (Interview 27, 2013 English).

For many Western aid workers, the uncovering of these religious tensions in Burmese society since 2012 has been a sobering experience. "I don't know how democracy can progress in a society where people have these kinds of views", was the conclusion of another European donor adviser (Interview 19, 2013 English). Reflecting on the long-term Western advocacy and support to the Burmese democracy movement, Thomas concluded, "Look at what [Western human rights organizations] are saying publicly [about Myanmar's democracy movement]. This country is going to hell. The forces that we have believed in, I don't see how we can work with them any more" (Interview 27, 2013 English).

While there has been widespread concern in international agencies about reactions to anti-Muslim violence, these perspectives are also positioned within a wider liberal narrative of "democratization". Reactions to communal violence are consistent with underlying narratives which construct certain problems and solutions for Myanmar's democratization. One crucial element in framing narratives is the question of how political struggle, contests, and conflict can be contained in society. Proponents of this liberal narrative assume that political contest in society is best contained through formal democratic institutions (Interview 39, 2014 English). Procedures and institutions, such as free and fair elections, a representative parliament, and an independent judiciary, can provide the structure where political contests can be removed from the personalized realm and placed in a formal one. One agency manager (Interview 4, 2013 English) suggested that, as countries democratize, they move from informal and personalized systems to formal and regulated ones.

Yet underlying the formal procedures of government — which may vary from country to country — many Western participants pointed to a set of underlying values. Perceived to be at the core of these is a commitment to the universality of human rights. Michael said that in discussing the issue of communal violence with local organizations, he sought to establish human rights as a common principle from which they may be able to build consensus (Interview 37, 2014 English). Yet he was deeply frustrated in his attempts: